

processed its transactions was concerning. Fortunately, Bitcoin's protocol is open-source software, which meant developers could download the entirety of its source code and tweak the aspects they felt most needed fixing. When the updated software was ready, the developers released it in a manner similar to how Bitcoin was originally released. The new software operated similarly to Bitcoin, but required its own set of developers to maintain it, miners to provide the hardware, and a separate blockchain to keep track of the debits and credits of the new native asset.

Through this combination of open-source software and ingenious programmers, many other cryptocurrencies have been brought into existence. Those that are only slight modifications of Bitcoin are often referred to as *altcoins*.

BITCOIN'S FIRST DIGITAL SIBLING

Namecoin¹⁵ was the first significant fork away from Bitcoin. Interestingly, it was less about creating a new currency and more about utilizing the immutable nature of the blockchain, a use case we'll address more in the next chapter. A website created with Namecoin comes with the .bit domain (as opposed to the .com domain) and provides security and censorship resistance to those sites registered with it.¹⁶

Namecoin grew out of an idea on the Bitcointalk forum in 2010 that focused on BitDNS (DNS stands for domain naming service, which handles all web addresses).¹⁷ In 2013, a service called NameID was released that uses the